

CONFEDERATE GENERAL (1807-91)

JOSEPH E. JOHNSTON



Virginian Joseph Eggleston Johnston was quartermaster general of the U.S. Army in April 1861 when he resigned to serve the Confederacy. Although made a full general by Davis, he developed a lasting feud with the Confederate president. When he was wounded at Seven Pines in May 1862, Davis replaced him with Robert E. Lee. After his recovery, Johnston held a series of commands in the Western Theater. His caution enraged Davis, but his skill in conducting a retreat demanded respect. Surviving the war, he was elected to Congress in 1878.

Johnston's reverse

Consistently overestimating Southern strength, McClellan was obsessed by the notion that his forces were insufficient. Lincoln's later decision to hold back troops to defend Washington and counteract Jackson's campaign in the Shenandoah Valley only fed McClellan's belief that he was being starved of resources. On the other side of the line, Confederate General Johnston was equally—but more rationally—convinced of the weakness of his army. In mid-April, Johnston took command at Yorktown, and planned to abandon the Peninsula and concentrate his forces in front of Richmond. On May 3, the Confederates abandoned Yorktown and the Warwick River defenses. Breaking contact with the enemy in a deftly executed maneuver, Johnston's troops, now numbering some 50,000, fell back toward Richmond. A part of the army was designated to fight a holding action on a defensive line at Williamsburg, and on May 5 this inflicted a reverse on pursuing Union troops. The fiercely fought encounter was almost as costly for both sides as the First Battle of Bull Run, despite the engagement of far smaller forces.